

Cultural Dialogue between Iran and the Subcontinent: Spirituality and Sufism

Sufi Poetry: a vehicle of strong bonding between Iran and the Subcontinent

By

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Abstract

The search for inner spirituality through a heightened spiritual experience has been a fundamental aspect of all living religions of the world. Sufism in Islam represents this quest for inner spirituality, which traces back its foundations to the simple and ascetic lifestyle of Prophet Muhammad and the divine word as revealed in the Quran. These two sources inspired the development of Sufism in the mediaeval period of Islam. Some of the Prophet's venerated companions, including Ali ibn Abi Talib, Abu Dharr al-Ghafari, Salman Farsi, and Uwais al-Qarani are among the spiritual ancestors of Sufism¹. The resistant but ascetic attitude of Muslim circles laid the foundation of Sufism in the late seventh and early eighth centuries. Following its noticeable appearance under the Umayyads the Sufi thought was further developed by Sufi saints, Imams and scholars under the Abbasids. Hasan al-Basri and Imam Jafar as-Sadiq are regarded as the two greatest teachers of Sufism. It began in Medina but blossomed in Iraq, Syria, Egypt, Persia, the subcontinent, Afghanistan and Central Asia. Sufism is a major discipline within Islam characterized by love and devotion for God, Prophet Muhammad and his family and the principles of humanity and tolerance.

The spiritual atmosphere created by Sufi poetry is central to the spiritual life in Islam. First composed in classical languages – Arabic and Persian – the Sufi verse is written in almost all the languages of the subcontinent. The famous forms of Sufi poetry in Persian and South Asian languages include *munajaat* or *munqabat*, *qasida*, *ghazal*, *ruba'i*, *masnawi*, *marsiya*, *kaafi*, *ginan*, *bara mah*, *athvara* and *siharfi*. This paper presents a brief account of the content and development of Sufi poetry in Persia and the subcontinent. It provides a brief sketch of the great classical Sufi poets in Persian and South Asian languages whose compositions have touched the lives of millions in Iran, Afghanistan and the subcontinent. The paper elucidates the strong influence of Persian on literary forms and genres of mystic poetry in the subcontinent. The Persian poetic tradition followed in the indigenous languages of the subcontinent is the vehicle to bring the people of Iran and the subcontinent together and create a lasting relationship.

¹ See Schimmel, Annemarie. 2003. *Mystical Dimensions of Islam*. Lahore: Sang-e-Meel Publications [Original work published 1975].

Introduction: Sufism in Islam

The search for inner spirituality through a heightened spiritual experience has been a fundamental aspect of almost all living religions. Sufism in Islam represents this quest for inner spirituality. Sufism is derived from the word Sufi and it is generally accepted that the origin of this word is *suf* in Arabic which means the coarse woollen garment that the early Sufis used to wear. The famous Sufi saint of the subcontinent Ali Usman Hujwiri, however, traces four possible roots of the word Sufi: “Some assert that the Sufi is so called because he wears a woollen garment (*jama-i suf*), others that he is so called because he is in the first rank (*saff-i awwal*), others say it is because the Sufis claim to belong to the *ashab-i Suffa*, (the people of the Bench who gathered around the Prophet’s mosque). Others, again, declare that the name is derived from *safa* – purity” (Hujwiri, 1959).

Aside from the debate on the origin and meaning of the word, Sufism traces back its foundations to the simple and ascetic lifestyle of Prophet Muhammad and the divine word as revealed through him in the Quran. These two sources – the Prophet’s ascetic life and the Quran – inspired the development of Sufism in the mediaeval period of Islam. According to Annemarie Schimmel (2003) ‘the Sufi tradition also includes some of Prophet Muhammad’s companions among the spiritual ancestors of Sufism. The list includes Ali ibn Abi Talib, Abu Dharr al-Ghafari, Salman Farsi, and Uwais al-Qarani. There are many who believe that esoteric wisdom was transmitted from Muhammad to his cousin and son-in-law Ali ibn Abi Talib, the fourth of the righteous caliphs (Schimmel, 2003: 28-30). Most Sufi disciplines or orders trace their lineage to Ali ibn Abi Talib.

Even though, the word Sufism was not in currency at the time of Prophet Muhammad but there was a group of the Prophet’s companions called *as’hab-e suffa* or ‘the people of the bench’ who used to sit on a bench outside the Prophet’s mosque in Medina. Renouncing the world, the group made the mosque their home and they devoted themselves to prayer and meditation. They were looked after by the Prophet and his family. These and later Sufis believed that Allah gave Prophet Muhammad two-fold knowledge: a) *ilm-e safina* or outer knowledge; and b) *ilm-e sina* or *ilm-e ladunni* meaning the knowledge of the heart. The Prophet bestowed inner knowledge to some of his venerated companions and especially to Ali ibn Abi Talib who the Sufis call *imam-ul auliya* or the Spiritual Leader of Walis. All Sufis have deep love and respect for *ahl-e bayt* or people of the house of Prophet Muhammad. The Sufis believe that “mystic knowledge enabled Prophet Muhammad to know everything in the world. The books of Hadith report on the authority of his companion Hudhaifa that the Prophet once arose speaking of everything that would happen on the Day of Judgment. The Messenger’s companions accepted that his knowledge surpassed the limits of human acquisition” (Dehlvi, 2009: 31).

Scholars believe that Sufism as a mystical belief and practice began after Prophet Muhammad, basically as a reaction against worldliness, impious and expansionist behavior of early Muslim rulers. The continuous expansion of the Muslim Empire, according to Schimmel, “made the pious ponder the discrepancy between the eschatological threat in the early Koranic [Quranic] revelations and the

necessity to expand the realms of Muslim rule by conquering more and more of the lands of the infidels” (Schimmel, 2003: 29). The rulers’ interest in conquest and expansion caused concern among the Muslim circles in Medina and Iraq where love for Prophet Muhammad and his family and adherence to the original path were strong. The resistant but ascetic attitude of Muslim circles laid the foundation of Sufism in the late seventh and early eighth centuries. Hasan al-Basri, the great Sufi of Iraq is among such Muslim scholars who, as pointed out by Schimmel (2003), sensing “the dangers inherent in a society that had become interested in conquest alone, in collecting wealth and worldly goods, while tending to forget the Koranic [Quranic] word”, urged his followers to live strictly according to the teachings of Prophet Muhammad and the Quran.

Following its noticeable appearance under the Umayyads (661-750 CE), the Sufi thought was further developed by the Imams, ascetics and scholars under the Abbasids (750 -1258 CE) and the Fatimid rule (909 -1171 CE). Hasan al-Basri and the Shia Imam Jafar as-Sadiq are regarded as the two greatest teachers of Sufism. Hasan al-Basri is among early theologians, jurists and ascetics of Islam. He was born to Persian parents in 642 CE near Medina. In Medina, al-Basri is believed to have been trained by Ali ibn Abi Talib. Al-Basri was fluent in both Arabic and Persian languages. He was known for his eloquent speech in Persian on ascetical matters. As is evident from his name al-Basri spent most of his life in Basra during the period of Caliphs Abdur Rahman and Abdul Malek. He continuously reminded people of the dangers of too much involvement in the worldly pursuits and total neglect of the afterlife. Even though Hasan al-Basri saw the Muslim rulers conquering over Gibraltar (*Jabal at-Tariq*), Sindh and Transoxiana but he did not like the Muslim rulers’ interest in conquests and collection of wealth and power (Schimmel, 2003).

An *Imam* (spiritual leader) of Shia Muslims Jafar as-Sadiq was also a prominent Islamic scholar, theologian, astronomer, alchemist, philosopher, writer and scientist. He is believed to be the teacher of the famous Muslim scientist Jabir ibn Hayyan, Imam Abu Hanifa, and Imam Malik ibn Anas, the founders of Hanafi and Maliki schools of jurisprudence respectively. The founder of Mutazilite school of thought Wasil ibn Ata is also reported to have attended his lectures. Jafar as-Sadiq is known among the Sufis of all disciplines and orders for his contribution to the development of the Sufi thought. As a scholar of the Quran he had a deep insight into the mystical phenomena. According to Schimmel, he recognized that there are four aspects of the Quran which include “expression, for the common people; allusion, for the privileged or elite; touches of grace (*lata’if*), for the saints; and finally the “realities” for the prophets” (Schimmel, 2003: 41). This very principle was developed into the stages and stations (*maqamat*) by the later Sufi masters.

Under the Abbasids, the Muslim empire came into contact with an outside world where the Muslims started interacting more closely with the Zoroastrians, Manicheans, Christians, Jews, Buddhists, and Hindus. This brought in significant impact on the Muslim learning and scholarship. Prominent Sufi thinkers of the eighth and ninth century contributed to further development and consolidation of a variety of interpretations in Sufism. Rabia al-Adawiya al-Basri, Zun Nun Misri, Bayazid Bistami, Junayd Baghdadi, and Mansur al-Hallaj were the Sufi masters of this period who had a deep and everlasting influence on the Sufi practice as a whole. For

example, the Sufi concept of perpetual cry in hope of divine help and forgiveness is associated with Hasan al-Basri. Other major concepts developed in the ninth century Sufism include *ikhlas* (absolute sincerity) put forward by al-Bishr and al-Muhasibi and *tawwakal* (absolute trust in God) by Shaiq al-Balkhi. Rabia al-Basri's primordial beauty and divine love have deep influence on the later Sufi practice continuing till this day. Zun Nun Misri is the first Sufi saint who introduced the theory of *marifa* (gnosis) or intuitive knowledge of God. He also introduced romantic mystical poetry consisting of small poems for the first time in Sufi literature. Bayazid Bistami is another Sufi saint who came from a small town of Iran called Bitsam. Like other Sufis he was also completely absorbed in the divine love. Bayazid formulated the concept of *fana* or annihilation and gave a spiritual interpretation to the experience of *miraj* or nocturnal journey of Prophet Muhammad. Another great Sufi master was Junayd Baghdadi who further developed the Sufi concept of *fana* (annihilation) and *baqa* (persistence of the real self in God). Mansur al-Hallaj was another great Sufi of Baghdad who was completely enraptured by the divine love. His tragic death as a result of a controversial trial is not only a symbol of martyrdom for divine love but it also depicts culmination of the early period of Sufism (see Dehlvi, 2009: 94-96). Intoxicated by the love of God he walked dancing to the gallows in the hope to be united with God. This has become a powerful image in both prose and poetry of almost all the major languages of the world.

In a nutshell, Sufism originated mainly as a symbol of peaceful resistance and adherence to the original precepts of Islam after Prophet Muhammad. It suffered a blow initially under the rulers who focused their attention and energies on worldly matters and expansion of the Muslim empire. It began in Medina but blossomed in Iraq, Syria, Egypt, Persia, Indo-Pak subcontinent, Afghanistan and Central Asia. Despite the fact that Sufism was suppressed by many a Muslim rulers in the past, it still remains the major discipline within Islam that follows the principles of love, humanity and tolerance. The Sufi path is followed by millions of Muslims around the world today. Throughout its history, Sufism has made enormous contribution to Islamic civilization.

Development and Content of Sufi Poetry

A follower who can follow a rigorous discipline and can trail the spiritual path to *marifa* can become a Sufi. The *salik* (journeyer or searcher) and *suluk* (the journey or search) are the two central elements of the Sufi path. As a first step of the journey (*suluk*), the *salik* starts traversing the wider road or *sharia* and then enters the narrower and difficult path of *tariqah* on which the *salik* has to pass through various stations called *maqamat* to reach the final and highest station of *marifa* or *haqiqa* meaning complete annihilation of self and merger into the Divine Light. The mystic verse or Sufi poetry has a great significance in the spiritual journey of Sufis. Mystic poetic texts in Arabic, Persian, Urdu and other languages are often intertwined with Quarnic quotations in the form of great contemplative poems. For example, much of Rumi's poetry is interspersed with the Quranic passages in a way that his poetry becomes a kind of *tafsir* or commentary on the Quran (Laude, 2005: 49-50; see also Nasr, 1972: 171). The contemplative poetry of Sufi poets is an essential element of the Sufi gatherings and ceremonies. This is the reason, the poetry composed by the

learned Sufi poets is recited and sung by men and women in villages and towns across the Islamic countries.

The Islamic mystic poetry is used to express love and devotion for God, Prophet Muhammad, and his family. It creates such a heavenly atmosphere and a world into which the human soul can withdraw for nourishment and protection. In the words of Hossein Nasr, “the vast majority of those who came to know of Sufism were attracted to it in the first place through poetry which then led them to the presence of the Sufi master. The poetry came in a way the main bridge which provided for those qualified among the general public access to Sufi teachings themselves” (Nasr, 1989: 6). Sufi poetry has exercised such an immense influence on the Muslim societies that majority of the people, even the so-called illiterate can recite the poetry in a language of their choice.

After the coming of Islam naturally Arabic was the first language to compose verses in praise of God, and eulogies of Prophet Muhammad and his family. The early hagiographies in Arabic have elements of the earliest mystic poetry in the form of aphorisms, *munajaat* (supplications) and poetic prose. *Nahj al-Balaghah* of Ali ibn Abi Talib and *al-Sahffat al-Sajjadiyyah* of his grandson Zain al-Abidin are the earliest examples in this regard. The use of aphorisms later continued through the works of great Sufi masters Hasan al-Basri, Bayazid Bistami, Zun Nun al-Misri and Junayd Baghdadi (Nasr, 2011: 2). The long lyrical poem *qasida*, a genre developed by pre-Islamic Arab poets and perfected by the Arabic and Persian Sufi poets, is the earliest verse form the Sufi poets have used and has perpetuated the Islamic literature. The *Qasida Burda Sharif* composed by Imam al-Busiri is the earliest and celebrated *qasida* in Arabic. Together with this, the *qasidas* composed by Abu al-Tayyib Ahmad al-Mutanabbi and Ibn al-Arabi are chanted to this day. It is basically through the Sufi poetry the *qasida* was introduced into Persian and later into Urdu.

The *ghazal* is another popular genre of Sufi poetry, which became a stand-alone poetic genre in the seventh century and continued flowering under Umayyads, Abbasids and Fatimids. Abdullah Jafar Rudaki (859-941 CE) is among the earliest and most praised *ghazal* poets from Persia. According to Jalajel (2007: 12), “the *ghazal*’s theme of longing proved particularly well suited to Persian mysticism”, which made it a “form devoted to the expression of the spiritual longing to be connected with the Divine”. The great Sufi poets Attar, Sana’i, Rumi, Sa’di, and especially Hafiz took the mystical *ghazal* to its apogee. *Ruba’i* or mystical quatrains attributed to Abu Said Abi’l-Khayr, Bishr ibn Yasin and Baba Tahir in the 11th century also became a medium for Sufi poets to express an intense love for God and possess a devotional tone (Nasr, 2011: 6).

The *masnawi* which literally means a ‘double one’ or rhyming couplet is another poetic genre that touched the heights of its popularity at the hands of the great Sufi masters. The *masnawi* as a poetic genre reaches its incomparable heights with Rumi whose the *Masnawi mawlawi manawi*, the extensive poem, “which is in reality an esoteric commentary upon the Quran, is an ocean of gnosis in which the whole teaching of the Sufi tradition is to be found ranging from doctrines to practical advice.” (Nasr, 2011: 8).

Marsiya, is yet another poetic form that the Sufi poets of South Asia have followed to compose poetry to mourn the martyrs of Karbala and particularly the tragic massacre of Imam Hussain and his family in 680 CE. Krishna (1930), Esmail (2002) and Asani (2006) have listed other indigenous poetic forms used by the poets of South Asia to compose the mystic verse. These include *kaafi*, *ginan*, *bara mah*, *athvara*, and *siharfi*. These verse forms are largely based on “the indigenous folk-poetic tradition, a tradition that was predominantly oral in character, meant to be sung or recited often with musical accompaniment. This tradition was maintained and preserved by women, who were the most important custodians of folksongs, proverbs and folk customs” (Asani, 2006: 4).

In terms of content, the inner meaning of the Quran, the love for God or Divine Love, love for the Prophet and his family are fascinating themes of the Islamic mystic poetry. The concept of Divine Love and its intense expression entered Sufi poetry through the earliest woman Sufi saint Rabia al-Adawiya of Basra. Later Sufi poets transformed Divine Love to *ishq*, a unique concept of love in Sufism, which has variously been explained as ‘absorbing love’; as ‘consuming love’; as ‘all-embracing love’. Ibn Arabi, Ibn al-Farid and Jalaluddin Rumi’s literary works crystallized this unique concept into *falsafa-ishq* or the philosophy of love (Malik, 1998: 41-42). From the thirteenth century onwards the complete Sufi doctrine concerning ‘the nature of reality’ also became a major theme of Sufi poetry and prose. Ibn Arabi’s works serve as the greatest example with regard to full flowering of the doctrinal exposition of Sufism (Nasr, 2011). Ibn Arabi also formulated another important concept in his doctrinal works that is *wahdat al-wajud* or transcendent unity of being which later dominated Sufi poetry in Persian, Urdu, Turkish and other languages.

Another perennial theme of Sufi poetry is that of *fana* or annihilation. Scholars generally agree that *fana*, the annihilation of one’s ego into God so as to find *baqa* – permanent life in God – was brought into Sufi literature by Abu Bakr al-Kharraz (d 899 CE). The idea of becoming one with the Beloved and casting of shackles of one’s own ego are beautifully expressed in mystic poetry (Rahman, 2009: 24). Transformation of man’s entire being, letters of alphabet, metaphors and symbols used in the Quran and the sayings of Prophet Muhammad have also echoed in the Sufi verse across all major and minor languages spoken in Muslim societies. Also, there are numerous poems in Persian, Urdu and other languages on *alif*, the first letter of Arabic, Persian and Urdu alphabet and the first letter in the word Allah:

*Those who have found the Lord alif, they
do not read again the Quran; O He.*

- Sultan Bahu (Translated by L.K. Krishna)

Persian Sufi Poetry

Through Sufism, Persian spread as a literary and cultural language from present-day Iran, Afghanistan and Tajikistan to Central Asia, the subcontinent and Turkey. Persian Sufi literature, in the words of Hossein Nasr “occupies a unique position not only in the history of Persia but in the whole of Islamic civilization. It is like what one would call a miracle of sacred art in its literary form which, for that very reason, broke out of the boundaries of the traditional Persian world where the Persian

language was spoken as the mother tongue and reached far beyond the borders of Persia, ... and create a literature which even today is shared in one way or another by the vast population living from Iraq through present-day Iran and all the way to the walls of China” (Nasr, 2011: 1).

Abdullah Jafar Rudaki (859-941 CE) is regarded as the first Persian poet whose works at the court of Samanids in Bukhara contain the first masterpieces of Persian poetry (de Fouchecour, 2006). Rudaki is also credited with inventing the *rubai* as a poetic genre and refining the Persian *ghazal*. Later, Abu Said ibn Abil Khayr (967-1049 CE) who was one of the greatest mystics of his age in Khurasan, his teacher Bishr ibn Yasin and a wandering dervish of the same period Baba Tahir Uryan, used the newly invented and popular *rubai* as their medium for expressing mystical ideas and experiences. They composed “dialect verses in a somewhat similar quatrain form to court the Heavenly Beloved” (Arberry, 2009: XVII).

The eleventh and twelfth centuries saw the first flowering of Persian Sufi literature when the Persian mystic poets used and perfected the *ghazal* and *rubai* to express their longing for the Divine Beloved. The *qasida*, earlier confined only to panegyric and satire was perfectly converted to express the ‘mystical love’ by the Ismaili mystic Nasir Khusrau of Badakhshan (d. after 1072 CE). Nasir Khusrau’s *Diwan* is “at once contemplative and moralistic, spiritual and philosophical, esoteric and rationalistic, ascetical and mystical” (Hunzai, 1996: 10). It was due to the works of these mystics and poets, Persian became ‘a sacred language’ and ‘the language of spirituality’. There is a vast literature and great many names in the Persian literature in Iran, Turkey, Afghanistan, South and Central Asia whose works contributed to the full flowering of mystical poetry between the eleventh and fifteenth centuries. Among these great masters whose poetry has exercised a deep influence on the people of Persia and South Asia include Abul Majd Majdud Sana’i, Farid ud-Din Attar, Jalaluddin Rumi, Shams-ud-Din Muhammad Hafiz Shirazi, Muslihuddin Sa’di Shirazi, and Nuruddin Abdur Rahman Jami. Rumi whose *ghazals* took “the Persian language to its extreme possibilities of expressing ecstasy of divine Union and the joy of hearing that celestial music which turns body and soul to rapture” (Nasr, 1989: 8); whose *masnawi*, “an esoteric commentary upon the Quran” and “an ocean of gnosis” (ibid) together with *sama* is his precious spiritual gift to the people of Turkey, Iran, Afghanistan, the subcontinent, Central Asia and countries across the world.

Abul Majd Majdud Sana’i better known as Hakeem Sana’i is the first poet to use the *ghazal* and *masnawi* to express philosophical, mystical and ethical ideas of Sufism. He took the *qasida* to its heights from the point his predecessor and compatriot Nasir Khusrau had left nearly fifty years ago (Lewis, 2000: 328). Lewis (2000) is of the view that Sana’i’s contribution to the *masnawi* provided a model for Jalaluddin Rumi’s own *Masnawi*. Farid ud-Din Attar is one of the most famous Sufi poets of Iran. Attar’s influence on the Persian Sufi poetry is so deep that even poets of Rumi’s stature were also inspired by Attar’s beautiful poetry. He spent years traveling in Baghdad, Basra, Kufa, Mecca, Medina, Damascus and other towns in Turkistan, Afghanistan, and the subcontinent. Through his poetry in Persian, Attar touched the hearts of millions in these lands. Shams-ud-Din Muhammad Hafiz Shirazi popularly known as Hafiz was born and lived in Shiraz. His *Diwan* is the most popular book wherever in the world Persian is spoken and understood. Most of his fans in the

subcontinent and elsewhere learn his poems by heart and recite them both in solitude as well as in front of others. His poetry became known to the West through Goethe and Emerson. Mystical love, the celebration of wine and intoxication, spring, flowers, and exposing hypocrisy prevalent in society are the major themes of Hafiz's poetry.

Muslihuddin Sa'di Shirazi popularly known as Sa'di is called "the greatest Persian poet of all time", "the greatest hero of Persian literature", and "Persia's national poet". Until recent times his greatest literary works *Gulistan* and *Bustan* were taught as textbooks of prose and poetry across the Persian-speaking world. Sa'di was a master of all the literary styles of his time and his greatest quality was his use of simplest and clearest expression both in poetry and prose. Nuruddin Abdur Rahman Jami is another great classical and mystical poet of Persia, who as prolific writer and especially as a poet "turned his hand at one time or another to every genre of Persian poetry and penned numerous treatises on a wide range of topics in humanities and religious science" (Losensky, 2008). He is the supreme master of using allegorical symbolism in the *masnawi* genre to describe different stages of the Sufi path.

Sufi Poetry in the Subcontinent

The subcontinent has produced some of the greatest Sufi mystics and poets. Besides Persian, these Sufi masters have composed some of the most beautiful mystic verses in the indigenous languages of the subcontinent such as Urdu, Bengali, Punjabi, Sindhi, Seraiki, Gujrati, Pashto, and Balochi. Persian which, remained the official language in mediaeval India has an everlasting impact on the languages of South Asia. In the words of Asani "Persian vocabulary features in all of the Northern languages" and has a strong influence "on literary forms, idioms and scripts of several languages...This is particularly true of Urdu, whose poetry cannot be truly understood in all its nuances without a thorough knowledge of the Persian poetic tradition" (Asani, 2006: 1). The earliest mystic poets of the subcontinent used Persian to compose the spiritual poetry. They used the popular poetic genres in Arabic and Persian including the *qasida*, *ghazal*, *rubai* and *masnawi* to compose mystic poetry.

Just before the great poet of Mediaeval India Amir Khusrau started using with eloquence all the literary genres in Persian to compose his beautiful poetry, Shehabuddin Mahmera, the panegyrist of Emperor Ruknuddin Firuzshah had introduced for the first time "spiritual themes within the spectrum of the *qasida*" (Casari, 2004). Qutb Jamal al-Din Ahmad Hasnawi (d. 1260), Ziauddin Nakhshabi, Hasan Sijzi (d. 1336), Shah Bu Ali Qalandar (d. 1323), Masud Beg (d. 1397), and Muhammad Gesudaraz (d. 1422) were among the earliest Persian poets of the subcontinent who contributed to the blossoming of Sufi poetry in the region. Later, the munificence of the Mughal Emperors in general and that of Akbar, Jahangir and Shah Jahan's courts in particular attracted an inflow of poets from Persia. Akbar was so interested in books that books were "read out to him regularly in his assembly hall. His library consisted of hundreds of prose books and poetical works in Arabic, Persian, Hindi, Greek and Kashmiri. But the books which the Emperor heard repeatedly were all in Persian" (Alam, 1998: 323).

The list of prominent Persian poets of the Mughal era by Alam (1998) and Casari (2004) includes Ghazali of Mashhad (d. 1572), Urfi Shirazi, Abul Faiz Faizi (1547-95), Abul Qasim Kahi (d. 1580), Talib Amuli (d. 1626), Husain Sanai, Qudsi Mashhadi (d. 1656), Abu Talib Kalim (d. 1650), and Sa'ib of Tabriz (d. 1677). Sarmad Kashani (d. 1659), a mystic close to Prince Dara Shikoh's circle, is another important poet who composed numerous mystic *rubaiyyat* (quatrains) of great beauty. He was beheaded under charges of heresy and apostasy by Mughal Emperor Aurangzeb. Nasir Ali Sirhindi (d. 1696) and Abdul Qadir Bedil (d. 1707) are among the native poets who wrote poetry of high standard in Persian. In the late seventeenth and eighteenth centuries, with the collapse of the last major Mughal dynasty and the arrival of the British Indo-Persian poetry gradually left its role, which passed into the hands of Urdu literature (Casari, 2004; Asani, 2006).

Scholars of Muslim literature in South Asia agree that the Sufi saints and poets played a key role in the development of literatures in local languages. In addition to Persian, the mystic poetry composed by Sufi poets in local languages was also the major vehicle of ideas, which played an instrumental role in the process of the Indian acculturation to Islam (Krishna, 1938; Asani, 1988 & 2006; Rahman, 2009). Starting with Baba Farid Ganjshakar (1173-1265) and Amir Khusrau (1253-1325), the Sufi verse in the indigenous languages of the subcontinent attained full maturity in the nineteenth century by the time of Khawaja Ghulam Fareed (1841-1901) and Mian Muhammad Bakhsh (1826-1907). The mystic poetry in the subcontinent originated in the Persian language. As the time went by, the great mystic poets of the land composed beautiful verses in local languages by adopting "the literary structures and forms prevalent in the indigenous folk-poetic tradition, a tradition that was predominantly oral in character, meant to be sung or recited often with musical accompaniment" (Asani, 2006: 4).

Like their Persian counterparts, the Sufi poets in South Asian languages also used the love for God; eulogies for Prophet Muhammad, his family and the mystics; mystical love; the Path and *marifah* (gnosis) as the central themes of their poetry. Their poems were basically intended for the common people who lived mainly in the rural areas of the subcontinent and did not understand Arabic and Persian. The Sufi poets in local languages made use of images and activities common in rural life in a particular region of the subcontinent. These images include spinning of cotton, ploughing, sowing, hunting, milking, world of nature and countryside. In coastal areas they also used the imagery of fishing and seafaring in their compositions. The mystics of the subcontinent also skillfully used romantic epics as a vehicle to convey Islamic mystical teachings. The use of popular romance in mystic poetry started probably in 1379 CE with the early Chishti poet Maulana Daud who "used the romance between Lurak and Chanda as a mystical allegory" (Asani, 2006: 5). Later the poets in Bengali, Punjabi, Sindhi and Pashto composed beautiful poems using local romantic epics and making the heroine of these epics "as the parable of the seeking soul on the mystical path who, separated from the Divine Beloved, must undergo great tribulation and painful purification process in her quest" (ibid). Together with the Persian genres of *qasida*, *ghazal* and *masnawi*, the Sufi poets of South Asia also used the local forms and musical modes in *kaafi*, *siharfi* and *dohra*. They made *kaafis* and *dohras* so popular that folksingers and *Qawwals* sing them to this day across all parts of the subcontinent.

Conclusion

Arabic was the first language that introduced mystic poetry in the form of aphorisms and supplications. The Arabic, and later Persian, poets perfected the pre-Islamic Arab genre of *qasida* to make it one of the most popular genres of Sufi poetry. The *ghazal*, another genre that the Arab poets used as a vehicle for romantic or erotic love, was used first by Rudaki in Arabic and later by the Persian poets to express the spiritual longing to be connected with the Divine. The great Sufi poets in Persian Attar, Sana'i, Rumi, Sa'di, and especially Hafiz took the mystical *ghazal* to its apogee. The *rubai* and *masnawi* are two popular forms of mystic poetry that touched their heights at the hands of Persian poets. It was largely the influence of Arabic that the Sufi poets in Persia began to write Persian poems. But, later Persian spread as a literary and cultural language over a vast area of Asia and exercised a great deal of influence to create a literature which even today is shared by a vast population. Persian remained the official language in mediaeval India, which has left an everlasting impact on the literary forms, idioms and scripts of the languages of the subcontinent. The earliest mystic poets of the subcontinent used Persian to compose their spiritual poetry using the genres of the *qasida*, *ghazal*, *rubai* and *masnawi*. With the blossoming of the mystic verse in the subcontinent, the great Sufi poets of the region also introduced indigenous forms such as *marsiya*, *kaafi*, *ginan*, *siharfi* and *dohra* to compose the spiritual poetry. In spite of the use of local symbols, images and romantic epics, the Sufi poetry in South Asian languages features Persian vocabulary and in some languages such as Urdu the poetry cannot be truly understood without the knowledge of the Persian poetic tradition.

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